and winning the argument at hand. Sending someone into a tailspin of religious faith wasn't the goal at all. Everett resolved not to show his proof to anyone devout again—but it was a resolution he couldn't keep. He showed the proof to religious friends on and off again for the rest of his life, unable to keep from delighting in the absurd.

Everett graduated from Catholic in 1953 and won a place in Princeton's physics PhD program. He had applied six weeks late, but it didn't matter, as the Princeton faculty were eager to meet such an extraordinarily talented student. Everett had scored in the 99th percentile on the brand-new physics GRE, and he had stellar letters of recommendation: "This is a once-in-a-lifetime recommendation.… Everett is by far the best student I have had at Princeton, Rutgers, or Catholic University. Everett has a better knowledge of mathematics than most of the graduate students at Catholic University and probably *no* graduate student is his equal in native ability." The National Science Foundation (NSF), also brand new, was similarly impressed, and paid for Everett's graduate tuition and stipend.

At Princeton, Everett became particularly close with three of his classmates, and they shared an apartment later on. "Everett was a lot of fun. He enjoyed needling people," recalled Hale Trotter, one of the three. "He was very competitive at whatever it was, if it was a poker game or it was ping pong," recalled another, Harvey Arnold. "[Everett] always wanted to go away the winner and he would make you stay there until he succeeded." Charles Misner, the final member of the trio, agreed, calling Everett "a brilliant oddball… [whose] favorite sport was one-upmanship," though Misner was hasty to point out that "it was always friendly competition" with Everett.

Everett's Princeton friends were also impressed with his brilliance. "It surprised me after I got to know him that he was as brilliant as he was," recalled Arnold. "It didn't come across until you got close to him. And then you would recognize that this guy would be on top of the world. He was smart in a very broad way. I mean, to go from chemical engineering to mathematics to physics and spending most of the time buried in a science fiction book. I mean, this is talent."

In his early days at Princeton, Everett put that talent to work in a mathematically rigorous field befitting someone with his sense of competition: the mathematical theory of games. Everett's interest was